**Revision Date:**
07/01/2024

**Background:**
Disaster CalFresh (DCF) provides temporary food assistance to households (HH) negatively impacted by a natural or man-made disaster.

**Purpose:**
This section describes policies for DCF benefits. This section has been revised to consolidate CalFresh Program Guide sections 63-501 through 63-508 and CalFresh Processing Guide 506-01. There are no changes being made due to state legislation.

**Policy:**
DCF is available when a Presidential Major Disaster Declaration with Individual Assistance (IA) has been declared for an affected area. The county must request authorization to operate DCF from the California Department of Social Services (CDSS) who will then request approval from Food and Nutrition Services (FNS). When approved by FNS the county may operate the DCF program under the conditions outlined in the request.

DCF is designed to provide one month's worth of food benefits to HHs affected by the disaster, who were **not receiving** CalFresh when the disaster occurred. The DCF allotment for a HH is equal to the maximum monthly allotment for the HH size provided under regular CalFresh. These amounts are updated on an annual basis, refer to Section 63-1101 Eligibility Standards Table for amounts.

HHs affected by the disaster who were **receiving** CalFresh in the month the disaster occurred may be eligible to disaster supplements. Disaster supplements may only be issued if a request to issue supplements was included in the county's DCF request that was approved by FNS. The disaster supplement amount will be the difference between the CalFresh benefits the HH received in the month the disaster occurred and the maximum monthly allotment for the HH size. Disaster supplements can be issued on an individual or an automatic/mass basis, depending on the conditions outlined in the approved DCF request.

1. Applying for DCF:

HHs must apply for DCF and meet eligibility requirements to receive benefits. DCF requests may be accepted in person, online or by phone during the approved DCF application period using the Application for Disaster CalFresh (CF 385). HHs may not submit a request for DCF by mail. The application period is usually seven days but may be extended with approval from FNS. All HHs applying for DCF must be interviewed. The date of the DCF application is the date the interview occurred. DCF applications must be dispositioned, and benefits made available to the HH within 72 hours from the date of application. Upon dispositioning the DCF, the HH must be issued a Notice of Approval/Denial for DCF (CF 390) along with an Electronic Benefit Transfer (EBT) card.

**Note**: DCF cannot be added to an already existing California Statewide Automated Welfare System (CalSAWS) case that has other programs besides DCF attached to it.

2. DCF Eligibility Requirements:

HHs must meet specific criteria during the DCF benefit period to be eligible to benefits. The benefit period is the 30-day timeframe in which HH income, resources, and disaster related expenses are

evaluated. The date the disaster occurred is generally used as the first day of the benefit period. The table below details the DCF eligibility requirements:

| Criteria | Description |
|---|---|
| Residency | HH must have lived or worked in the disaster area at the time the disaster occurred. A HH residing in a temporary shelter providing all meals during the disaster benefit period is ineligible to DCF. However, the HH is eligible to DCF if they leave the shelter before the end of the application period.<br>**Note**: HHs not residing in the county during the application period but who lived or worked in the affected area at the time of the disaster meet the residency requirement. |
| Purchase of Food | HH must have purchased food or plan on purchasing food during the disaster benefit period. |
| Adverse Effect | HH must have experienced one of the following adverse effects because of the disaster: |

| Adverse Effect | Description |
|---|---|
| Disruption of income | Income was reduced, terminated or there was a delay in receipt of income during the disaster benefit period. |
| Inaccessible liquid resources | Liquid resources could not be accessed during the disaster benefit period. |
| Paid disaster-related expenses | Paid out of pocket disaster related expenses during the disaster benefit period that are not expected to be reimbursed. |
| Food Loss | Experienced food loss because of the disaster. |

| | |
|---|---|
| DCF Income and Resource Test | HHs must pass the DCF Income and Resource Test to be eligible for benefits. |

3. DCF HH Composition:

The HH composition is established as of the date the disaster occurred or as specified in the Presidential Declaration. A DCF HH includes individuals who are living together and purchasing and preparing food together at the time of the disaster. A DCF HH does not include individuals with whom applicants are temporarily staying due to the disaster or individuals who moved in after the disaster occurred.

4. Previously Excluded HH Members:

Previously ineligible or excluded HH members are eligible to apply for DCF. The following individuals may apply for DCF:

- Ineligible non-citizens.
- Ineligible students.

- Sanctioned/Disqualified HH members.
- Intentional Program Violators.
- Strikers.
- Voluntary Quit.
- Able Bodied Adults Without Dependents (ABAWD).

**Note:** Previously ineligible or excluded HH members must apply for their own DCF and cannot be included in the HHs disaster supplement.

5. DCF Income and Resource Test:
DCF applicants must pass the DCF Income and Resource Test. DCF uses net income in its budget, not gross income as used in the CalFresh budget. Net income includes the following:

- The wages a HH received after taxes and all other payroll withholdings.
- Public assistance payments.
- Other unearned income.
- Net self-employment income.

To determine if the HH passes the DCF Income and Resource Test, follow the steps below:

| Step | Action |
|---|---|
| 1 | Determine the total **net** income received and/or reasonably certain to be received during the disaster benefit period. |
| 2 | **Add** the accessible liquid resources to the total net income. |
| 3 | **Subtract** allowable disaster-related expenses paid or expected to be paid during the benefit period. Disaster related expenses include, but are not limited to:<br>• Home or business repairs, damaged vehicle expenses.<br>• Evacuation expenses, pet boarding fees, storage fees.<br>• Medical expenses, funeral expenses.<br>• Expenses related to replacing personal items.<br>• Replacement of spoiled or lost food. |
| 4 | **Compare** the total to the DCF Income Limit found on the CalFresh Assistance Standards Table in Eligibility Essentials. |
| 5 | If the total is less than the DCF Income Limit for the HH size, the HH is **eligible** to DCF. |
| 6 | If eligible, issue the customer the DCF Maximum Allotment, which is equal to the regular CalFresh maximum allotment amount for the HH size. |
| 7 | If the total is more than the DCF Income Limit for the HH size, the HH is **not eligible** to DCF. |

Below is an example of how to compute the DCF Income and Resource test:

| **Example: DCF Income and Resource Test** | |
|---|---|
| Scenario | Laura and her three children live with her mother Joan. They purchase and prepare together. They are not receiving CalFresh at the time the disaster occurred. Laura receives monthly net earned income of $850. |

<table>
<tr><td></td><td>Joan receives monthly net earned income of $1200. Laura has $50 in her savings account and Joan has $200 in her checking account. The resources are accessible. Joan's car was damaged in the disaster. Joan paid $500 out of pocket to repair the car. Laura paid $800 out of pocket for evacuation expenses. They will not be reimbursed for these expenses.</td></tr>
<tr><td>Eligibility Determination</td><td>
<table>
<tr><th>Step</th><th>Action</th></tr>
<tr><td>1</td><td>Determine the HH's total net income:
<table>
<tr><td>Joan's net earnings</td><td>$1200</td></tr>
<tr><td>Laura's net earnings</td><td>$850</td></tr>
<tr><td>Total HH net income</td><td>$2050</td></tr>
</table></td></tr>
<tr><td>2</td><td>Add accessible liquid resources:
<table>
<tr><td>Joan's savings</td><td>$200</td></tr>
<tr><td>Laura's checking</td><td>$50</td></tr>
<tr><td>Total accessible liquid resources:</td><td>$250</td></tr>
</table></td></tr>
<tr><td>3</td><td>Subtract allowable disaster related expenses:
<table>
<tr><td>Car repair</td><td>$500</td></tr>
<tr><td>Evacuation expense</td><td>$800</td></tr>
<tr><td>Total disaster related expense:</td><td>$1300</td></tr>
</table></td></tr>
<tr><td>4</td><td>Compare net income with DCF income limit for HH size:
<table>
<tr><td>Total net income</td><td>$1000</td></tr>
<tr><td>DCF Income Limit for HH 5</td><td>$3555</td></tr>
</table></td></tr>
<tr><td>5</td><td>The net income is less than the DCF Income Limit, the HH is eligible for DCF.</td></tr>
</table>
</td></tr>
</table>

6. <u>DCF Verification Requirements</u>:
The only mandatory verification for DCF is identity of the applicant. All other verifications may be accepted through customer statement. The table below details verification requirements for DCF:

| Applicant Information | Verification Requirement |
|---|---|
| Identity | Mandatory for applicant. |
| Residency, HH composition, loss or inaccessibility of income or liquid resources, food loss, Social Security Number (SSN), citizen/noncitizen status or disaster related expenses | Customer statement, unless questionable. |

If information provided is questionable and verification is required, send the HH a verification checklist giving them 7 days to provide the requested verification. If verification is not provided by the seventh day, deny DCF.

7. Disaster Supplements:
When the approval to operate DCF includes individual disaster supplements, HHs who received CalFresh in the month the disaster occurred must apply for supplements using the Replacement or Supplement Affidavit/Authorization (CF 303). The CF 303 may be submitted in person, online or by phone. As the HH's income and composition are already known to the county, the HH is not required to complete an interview. To be eligible to disaster supplements the HH must attest on the CF 303 that it experienced at least one of the following adverse effects due to the disaster:

- Loss or disruption of income.
- Incurred disaster related expenses.
- Inability to access liquid resources.
- Loss of food.

HHs must be issued a Notice of Action (NOA) informing them of the outcome of the disaster supplement request. The NOA is the CF 303, with the "County Use" section completed.

Below is an example of a CalFresh HH applying for disaster supplement benefits:

| **Example: HH Eligible for Disaster Supplement** | |
|---|---|
| Scenario | HH of 5 applying for DCF, all HH members had active CalFresh during the benefit period and were issued $872. HH eligible to apply for disaster supplement benefits. |
| Outcome | Customer had adverse effect due to disaster. Maximum monthly allotment for HH of 5 is $1155, HH is eligible to disaster supplement benefit of $283. |

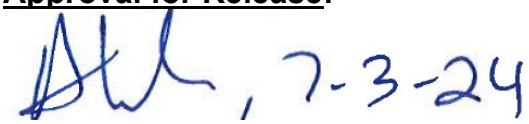
8. Overissuance (OI):
When a HH receives DCF benefits to which it was not entitled, an OI claim must be established following the same claims collection policy and guidelines as CalFresh.

9. Food Distribution Program on Indian Reservations (FDPIR):
If the HH received their monthly FDPIR prior to the date the disaster occurred, the HH may potentially be eligible to DCF. If a HH received their monthly FDPIR benefits after the disaster occurred, the HH would not be eligible to DCF.

**References:**
Manual of Policies and Procedures (MPP) 63-900
All County Letters (ACLs) 06-37; 18-125; 19-95; 87-158
All County Information Notice (ACIN) I-64-22

**Sunset Date:**
This policy will be reviewed for continuance by 07/31/2027.

**Approval for Release:**



Rick Wanne, Director
Self-Sufficiency Services